

COURSE : APPROACHES TO CULTURE AND COMMUNICATION

COURSE INSTRUCTOR : VISHVAJIT PANDYA

PC 721

Honour Code

Academic dishonesty cheating, plagiarism or any kind of deceit- will not be tolerated, and will result in a zero for the assignment. If you have any questions about what constitutes plagiarism, please ask. All ideas and words that you did not generate yourself must be cited in your papers. I do not anticipate this scenario for the work required in this class, but in extreme cases I reserve the right to assign a failing grade for the course or a specific assignment.

LEARN TO TAKE LECTURE NOTES AND KEEP A SMALL NOTE BOOK TO WRITE IDEAS AND WORDS THAT YOU DO NOT UNDERSTAND AND LOOK UP THE MEANING OR ASK IN CLASS. BUT MAKE A NOTE WHERE THE QUESTION ORIGINATED FROM.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

Communication between any form of transmitter and recipient is not just a matter of 'hardware' and 'software'. Communication, what it achieves, how it is interpreted, what is understood, conveyed and represented involves social ideology, cultural techniques and whole society's historical context. After all communication does not take place in vacuum! By the 18th century, mainly in western world, development of print culture lead to creation and evolution of a modern 'public culture'. This included process of identifying, weighing, and discussing the issues of the day in ways hardly possible before the print revolution.

This multidisciplinary approach seminar course students could explore the inter relationship of orality, writing. Printing, the visual image, theatre and music, by encouraging students to research and discuss the interaction between various modalities

of communication within Indian society and history. We intend to examine how culture communicates and communication creates culture with particular intent to consider relationship between image and sound.



This course based on a seminar format. It is aimed to develop conceptual schemes and patterns by which historically (changing times-including future and its base in past) ideas objects and actions have been developed and or evolved to communicate within Indian culture and its contextual positioning with other cultures as broad as colonialism and globalization. This locating in understanding may include broadly language socialization, literacy, music and the visual arts, the power of language, miscommunication, and universal and culture-specific properties of human communication as embodied in ritual performances, organized spectacles and structured events in public spaces.

Utilizing the ideas from Anthropology, Sociology, Semiotics History and Cultural Studies the course first will provide some understanding of basic conceptual and analytical foundations. So actual context and its depiction (ethnographic case) will be presented to you along with analytical frameworks that can be derived from it (theoretical)

The course expects you to be open minded, critical and think about society and culture beyond India. You are expected to acquire basic sensibility to various assumptions about how and why societies communicate. The readings for each section will be dealt in the class as discussion sessions with student participation and presentation. Do not expect that lecture would solely be based on the readings. Readings are just a base to back up the ideas presented by the faculty.

COURSE CONTENT AND THEMES

With globalization, the Internet, and the general shrinking of time and space, cross-cultural interaction has become a necessity in people's everyday lives. This course is designed to interrogate different aspects of cross-cultural communication and cultural differences: family life, social relationships, the workplace, government, education, gender, romance, and religion. Throughout exploring these topics, we will strive to engage in personal self-reflection, hands-on experience, and to understand the connections to larger social structures.

Specifically, the goals of this course are: 1) to describe, learn, and see common and important patterned social and cultural differences, 2) to provide a space for students to reflect on their own personal experience with cultural difference, and 3) to encourage students to engage with different cultures in a hands-on way and to meaningfully experience cross-cultural communication.

EVALUATION : CONTINUOUS EVALUATION AND RESEARCH PAPER

- **You are expected to attend the lectures and participate in all the discussions and undertake the assignments based on readings, above and beyond the provided references.** Your active and informed participation in the class has impact on your grade. Individuals must develop the capacity to think critically, support their point of view by well-informed arguments and creative research and observations from real contexts.
- Sequence of lectures will cover some essential ideas that the course intends to impart to you.
- **The lectures would then be followed by discussion** around readings that would help you to understand the basic ideas in relation to concrete specific cultural case.
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- **The 'research project' has to be turned in by individual student as a researched paper (double spaced typed of 10 to 12 pages, 12pt.font, normal margins) focusing on a theme provided by the faculty.** You are expected to consult the course coordinators to develop your research topic. This project has to be presented by individual in the classroom as a presentation.

- **Your final project and presentation would be worth 55 % and remaining 45% of your grade will be accounted by your class participation, assignments and presentations as well as pop quiz.**

DETAILED COURSE PLAN

1. What is a communication event? What are it's elements and aspects-
 'Concepts of Culture' Visual Culture Walker and Chaplin. pp 7-17
 'How culture Conditions the Colours we see' Umberto Eco.
2. Semiology of ideology and history..
 'Experience, Re-presentaion and Film' Deveau, L in Fields of Vision (ed)) pp 56-73
 'What we do when we believe' Mihel De Certeau.
 'Signs, Symbols, Imaginary' Jacques Lacan.
 'Pandora's Box: How and why to Communicate 10,000 Years into the future.'
 Thomas A Sebeok.
3. Interpretability of Culture
 Rathwa Pithoro: Writing about Writing and Reading Painted Ethnography.
 Pandya V. 2004 Visual Anthropology, Volume 17 No.2 April-June pp117-161
 'Deep Play: Notes on the Balinese Cockfight' Clifford Geertz.
 .Ramanujan A K 'Is there an Indian way of Thinking'.
4. Semiotic events and History
 'Myth Today' Barthes, R. in Mythologies 1957 pp 109-159
 'Introduction: The Agony of Semiotics Reassessing the Descipline' Blonsky Marshall.
 'Representations of India' Pinney 1989 Pacific View Point Vol29 No 2.
 "From Photography: Ethnography: Andamanese Documents and Documentation" In Visual Anthropology PandyaV 1991 Vol 4 Nos 3-4 pp.379-413

'Imaging Process as Ethnographic Inquiry' Caldroda,V 1988 Visual Anthropology Vol 1 433-456

6. Seeing and Showing in Indian culture portability.
Paul Stoller 1986 Eye Mind and Word in Anthropology In The Taste of Ethnographic Things, The Senses in Anthropology pp37-55
'Vision Mixing...' Shuddhabrata Sengupta in *Image Journeys* (ed) Brosius & Butcher 1999 pp 279-307
'Transnational Class, Erotic Arcadia and Commercial' R. Inden In *Image Journeys* (ed) Brosius & Butcher 1999 pp 41-68
7. Signification
David MacDougall 1997 The Visual in Anthropology In Banks and Morphy (ed) Rethinking Visual Anthropology pp 276-95
Banks, M 'Representin the bodies of the Jain' In Banks and Morphy (ed) Rethinking Visual Anthropology pp 216-239
'Anthropological Aspects of Language Animal Categories and Verbal Abuse' Leach, E
8. Mythology and its analysis
'The Structural Study of Myth' Levi-Strauss, C
Veena Das 1995 On soap opera: what kind of anthropological object is it? In Daniel Miller (ed) Worlds Apart:Modernity through the Prism of the local. Routledge London pp169-189
'Representing, Resisting, Rethinking Historical Transformation of Kayapo Culture and Anthropological Consciousness' Terence Turner In George W Stocking (ed) Colonial Situations pp 285-313
'Photography that Listens' Larson, H 1988 Visual Anthropology Vol 1 pp 415-432.
'Media Friends or Media Foe?' Mac Dougal D 1987 Visual Anthropology1 54-58
'Structuralism'

B. EVENTS, EXHIBITIONS, & MULTI MEDIA (OPTIONAL)

1. Case of MOMA

'Histories of the Tribal and the Modern' James Clifford in *The Predicament of Culture*. 1988 Harvard University Press pp 189-214

'Museums as Contact Zones' James Clifford in *Routes*. 1997 Harvard University Press pp 188-219.

"Visions of the Nation" S Freitag in *Pleasures and the Nation* 2001 (ed) Dwyer & Pinney. Pp 35-75. also see 'Introduction' pp 1-34

"Hot Scorpions, Sweet Peacocks: Kuchche Art, Architecture and Action"

Pandya V. 1998 *Journal of Material Culture*. March (3:1) pp 51-75.

2. Case of Andamanese clay painting

'Undoing the Ethnographic' Gimblett, B in *Destination Culture* .1998 California University Press. Pp 201-256.

See **Pandya Above the Forest (relevant Section- in library)**

3. Viewer, reader and agency

Paul Stoller 1986 *Eye Mind and Word in Anthropology* In *The Taste of Ethnographic Things, The Senses in Anthropology* pp37-55

Kristen Hastrup 1992 *Anthropological Visions: Some Notes on Visual and Textual Authority* In Peter Ian Crawford and David Turton (eds) *Film as Ethnography*. New York pp8-25.

'The Aesthetics and Politics of Colonial Collecting' Breckenridge 1989 *Comparative Study of Society and History* pp 195-216

'The Photograph as an intersection of Gaze' Lutz and Collins *Visualizing Theory* (ed) Taylor L 1994 pp 363-384

'Electronic Ceremonies: Television performs a royal ritual' D. Dayan and E. Katz

4. Masking and puppet theatre Transformation.

'The Third Eye' Napier D In *Masks, Transformation, and Paradox* pp 135-187.

5. Subject –Object relationship

‘Art As Culturally Significant Meaning’ Anderson R. in Calliope’s Sisters. Pp238-84.

‘The Market Wheel- Symbolic Aspects of an Indian Tribal Market’ Gell,A 1982
MAN 17(3) 410-91